herself (when there was no on-line booking and one had to wait in long queues), she faced the challenges, on and off the court, as they came.

* * *

Kiran believes that her attitude towards, and strategies for, life have been developed from her tennis. The game taught her many things that she would not otherwise have learnt from any book. Academics and sports could both be pursued together provided one had the single-minded determination to succeed in both fields. But then one had also to be prepared to miss out on some other recreations. Such recreations could come in their own time, later in life, but during the period of struggle and foundation laying, they had to be assiduously avoided. The rewards she knew would be adequate compensation in themselves.

Tennis taught her the value of hard work and perseverance and how important it was (and is) to be both mentally and physically strong. She would resort to autosuggestion often and would think of nothing but victory. She ran miles every day to keep herself fit and divided her time judiciously between studies and intensive sports practice. The self-confidence she has always exuded is the reward of her self-training. She also attributes her qualities of fair play, team work, concentration, indefatigability, endurance, tenacity and, most of all, that ability to go the extra mile, under conditions of stress and exhaustion, to her years on the tennis courts.

Kiran recalls how she was exposed to a considerable amount of gender and class bias those days. Despite the fact that men were always paid more than women, the latter had to constantly assert themselves to obtain what was legitimately due to them. Players from metropolitan cities were considered ‘more equal’ than those belonging to, for instance, Amritsar, which was disparagingly dubbed ‘an urban village’. A particular case reveals the extent of the prejudice against women. Kiran used to call the secretary of the Punjab Tennis Association, Shamsher Singh, her ‘uncle’. This ‘uncle’ would often make her wait for hours outside his office when she went to collect her railway concession forms, but she was thankful that he had been considerate enough to have at least a washed out wooden bench there. It was this endless waiting that made her promise herself if ever she were in a position to give someone something, she would never ever make that person wait.

In 1966, when she was the national junior champion, there was a tradition that this individual would represent the country at the junior Wimbledon championships. But it was this very same ‘uncle’ who broke the tradition and cancelled her trip for his own vested interests. This incident all the more drove home the message for Kiran that she was not going to rely on tennis to make a career. She would play the game and compete to learn.

Another vital lesson she learned from her tennis was the ability to not let the effect of what others would say override her own interests. For a girl more concerned with working hard at achieving the targets she had set for herself rather than adding frills, she would often even attend weddings and functions in her sports outfit. To go home and change would have meant sacrificing precious time from her tennis schedules, and she certainly seemed to have her priorities cut out for herself. Her achievements even at that very young age had made her feel confident that she did not have to feel less than anyone else because she knew that she had achieved much more than her peers. Her family had become a recognized tennis family that had brought laurels to the state of Punjab. Kiran had won for Punjab the state title, the zonal title, the national title and finally the Asian title. Along with her sister Reeta she won the interuniversity title thrice. The youngest of the Peshawaria sisters, Anu, later became the national champion for three years running and played not only the university, state and the Asian championships, but also at Universiad and Wimbledon. Anu’s son Aditya has won many